

CARL LEWIS

It is said that the young Carl Lewis was so small and short that his sister used to jocularly call him “shorty.”

He then had such a spurt in height at 15 that his parents had to put him in crutches for more than three weeks. When he moved from his hometown of Willingboro to the University of Houston, he found himself well within the trappings of a hero-in-the-making. At 19,

he was selected to represent his country at Moscow 1980 but had to stay at home as the US chose to boycott the Games. Lewis emerged as the biggest draw at Los

Angeles 1984, with gold in the 100m, 200m, long jump and the 400m relay.

Lewis did not disappoint at Seoul 1988 as he finished with two more gold medals and a silver, earning his second consecutive crown — the first by an athlete at the Games — in the long jump, and was then given pole position in the 100m after Canadian Ben Johnson was stripped of the gold medal following a positive dope test.

Four years later in Barcelona, Lewis again won two gold medals, in the long jump and the 400m relay, before becoming the third athlete to win four on the trot at Atlanta 1996 where, at 35, he was nowhere near his best but still managed to leap to a resounding victory.

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